

Private vets have an important role to play in emergency animal disease responses in Australia.

In 2011 an [independent review into Australia's preparedness for foot-and-mouth disease](#) found that employment conditions in state and territory jurisdictions were not consistent. This could act as a barrier to engaging vets in an emergency.

A national, consistent set of conditions for engaging private vets are now in place.

These arrangements allow private veterinarians to be directly engaged by state or territory governments as temporary or casual government employees, or as contractors at a nationally agreed remuneration rate.

This policy document was developed to assist private veterinarians and jurisdictions implement the new arrangements.

- [National Guidance document on the Engagement of Private Veterinarians during an Emergency Animal Disease Response](#) - updated June 2023.

[View our digital story](#) featuring the experiences of two private veterinarians previously involved in an emergency animal disease outbreak.

Frequently Asked Questions

A major EAD outbreak could have a significant impact on animal welfare, human health, the environment, and the economy.

As a veterinarian, you will be essential to limiting the size and scale of the impact. For many it can be a lifechanging experience. You will be able to:

- contribute to a national response that helps affected industries and communities;
- interact with veterinary colleagues across the profession;
- gain valuable experience.

Emergency response roles will depend on your training and skills. You will be matched to an appropriate position. This may be in the field or in a control centre.

During a response, the largest number of skilled vets are needed for tasks such as field surveillance and vaccination.

State and local control centres may need vets with specific skills. These could be epidemiology and welfare skills and other industry specific knowledge.

All registered vets in Australia are eligible to be involved in an EAD response. There are also roles for unregistered vets and vet students who want to help.

Registered vets are encouraged to help in a response; however you are not legally obliged to be involved.

All vets have a legal obligation to report signs of a possible emergency animal disease. Report any unusual signs or suspected cases of emergency animal disease immediately to the Emergency Animal Disease Hotline on 1800 675 888. Early reporting increases the chance of effective control and eradication.

Registered vets

As a registered veterinarian, there is further information below on the different ways you can be engaged to work in an EAD response.

Registered veterinarians are able to work on an EAD response across Australia. National Recognition of Veterinary Registration (NRVR) is now in place, which allows vets registered in one state or territory to work in another.

For queries about your registration, contact your veterinary registration body. See more about [working across jurisdictions](#).

If you are no longer registered as a veterinarian, there are a range of roles that will need to be filled during a response and unregistered vets are likely to be utilised if available. You will be paid according to the salary rates being paid to non- professional, temporary response staff. You need to approach the veterinary registration board in your state or territory if you wish to become registered.

Retired veterinarians

If you are still registered, but retired, you may be employed by a state or territory or engaged as an individual contractor.

As an individual contractor, you will need professional indemnity and public liability insurance. It will need to cover the term specified in the contract (usually 7 years).

Check how this works with your insurance company. They can confirm if you will incur costs after the response.

Veterinary students

There are a range of roles to be filled during a response. Veterinary students are likely to be engaged if available. This will provide you with very useful training and experience.

Students will be paid the same salary rates as all non-professional, temporary response staff.

Overseas vets

Australia, Canada, Ireland, New Zealand, the UK and the USA have an agreement in place to provide help when required during an EAD outbreak.

The Australian Government manages these international emergency veterinary reserves.

There are 3 ways that registered veterinarians can work in an EAD response.

This may be:

- as a temporary or casual government employee (through a state/territory jurisdiction);
- as an individual contractor that provides specific services to the responding state or territory;
- as an employee of a private veterinary practice that is contracted to engage in the response.

Employee vets (whether by government or through a practice) will have their insurance covered by the employer. Individual contractors or contracting businesses must cover the costs of their own insurance.

Contractor roles are most likely vets working semi-independently. This includes roles in active disease surveillance, vaccination, and field euthanasia.

Pay and conditions will depend on how you are engaged, which is detailed further below.

For more information on the [difference between employees and contractors](#) please see the [ATO website](#).

The Australian states and territories have agreed to use Australian Government pay rates as the benchmark for employee veterinarians.

There are 3 primary levels of remuneration. Vets will be paid according to these levels, aligning the salary with the applicable state/territory industrial agreement.

Employed by government

Pay table for staff employed by government

Level Eligibility		Department of Agriculture Salary per annum (as of June 2023)
NGV1	Practitioner with less than 5 years relevant experience since graduation	\$98,072 (APS6.04)
NGV2	Practitioner with more than 5 years relevant experience since graduation or has appropriate area(s) of expertise	\$105,073 (APS6.06)
NGV3	Practitioner with more than 5 years relevant experience since graduation with the completion of additional training for roles in a Local Control Centre or State Control Centre. Roles include coordinator of tracing, coordinator of surveillance, infected property operations etc.	\$124,609 (APS6.08)

Insurance

As an employee, you will not need your own insurance. You will be covered by government insurance arrangements.

Expenses

Personal protective equipment, consumables, accommodation, and meal allowances are all provided.

A motor vehicle will generally be supplied if required. Mileage rates will be paid for the use of private vehicles if required.

Benefits

If you are employed on a full-time or part-time basis you will be entitled to:

- superannuation,
- overtime
- workers compensation
- recreation and sick leave.

If you are employed on a 'casual' basis you will not be eligible for benefits such as paid leave or public holidays. Casual employment is generally used where the hours are variable. For casual staff, a loading is normally applied to the base salary level. This is generally between 15 and 25% but varies between states and territories.

Contractors

Contractors will receive a \$223.65 per hour (excluding GST) with a maximum of 10 hours per day.

The contractor rate is all-inclusive. There are no extra employee entitlements. Some out-of-pocket expenses will be paid by the relevant state or territory.

The intent is a single national rate of pay that applies in all states and territories. Rates will not be negotiated by individual veterinarians or practices.

Insurance

Individual contractors MUST be covered by professional indemnity and public liability insurance (to the value of \$10 million). Practices must have workers compensation for their staff; appropriate personal accident and motor vehicle insurance is also recommended.

If you do not have insurance, you may be able to be engaged:

- by a contracted veterinary practice
- as a state or territory employee.

This would mean you are covered under the employer's insurance arrangements.

Expenses

The state or territory government will pay for:

- mileage at the Australian Taxation Office rate

- accommodation costs (where staying away from your normal place of residence).

Contractors will need to supply some of their own equipment. This could include personal protective equipment and basic consumables.

Major response consumables, for example vaccines, will be paid for and supplied by the state or territory.

Billable versus non-billable activities

Billable activities will be detailed within the contract but are likely to cover:

- time from when veterinarians leave their base, perform the work and return
- time required to complete paperwork relevant to the work performed e.g. filling in surveillance and sample collection forms
- time undertaking response specific induction training.

Non-billable activities likely to be excluded from the contract are:

- providing support to delivering the work performed e.g. invoicing, booking appointments and sourcing supplies
- managing staff for technical competence
- managing work health and safety requirements
- managing human resources such as rostering

How the hourly rate was calculated

The contractor hourly rate was determined by applying a “multiplier” to the hourly employee rate. The hourly rate is set by the DEE (Biosecurity) Agreement Veterinarian classification salary.

A working group agreed to this multiplier. They consisted of:

- private veterinarians (through the Australian Veterinary Association),
- state and territory government representatives.

This agreement acknowledges the competing responsibilities and accountabilities of all involved in an EAD response.

The multiplier is based on the productivity rate, rather than the charge out rate.

Productivity rate is derived from the proportion of veterinary wages to the total revenue the veterinary clinic generates.

Charge out rate is usually higher. It accounts for non-billable time the vet needs to complete tasks associated with delivering a service (e.g. record keeping).

Staff employed by a private practice

Sometimes staff at private veterinary practice are involved in an EAD response through their employer. In this case, you will receive your usual rate of pay and conditions as an employee of that practice.

When you provide veterinary services to a veterinary practice's clients the charge out rate to the client is higher than the veterinarian's hourly pay rate. This is because of the fixed and variable expenses associated with running a veterinary practice, of which the veterinary wages are just one component. The same rationale is used for practices that are contracted to provide veterinary services in the event of an EAD response. Your practice will pay your insurances. This includes professional indemnity (\$10 million) and public liability (\$10 million). They also cover all other conditions and practice operational expenses, including superannuation, leave, workers compensation, vehicles, equipment, consumables and support staff.

Read our [advice for private vet practice owners](#).

Review of salary and contractor rates

The national guidance document will be reviewed every 3 years by the Animal Health Committee (AHC). Pay rates will be adjusted in line with the Australian Government Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry enterprise agreement.

The state or territory will try to give an estimate of the length of engagement.

As a contractor or contracted practice, the allocation of work is determined by the Control Centre. A Local Control Centre is responsible for operations (eradication and control) in one or more defined areas where the outbreak is occurring. A State Coordination Centre has primary responsibility for coordinating activities across the state or territory. The contractual arrangements (including length of engagement) will be determined by the state/territory.

As an employee of a state or territory, you will be appointed either:

- full-time or part-time for a fixed term (during the EAD response)
- or on a casual basis.

All vets must be aware of emergency animal disease threats. All veterinarians are encouraged to utilise EAD training opportunities and develop their skills in this area.

There are a variety of courses and workshops available, such as through [Animal Health Australia](#).

Preparing for an outbreak

Prior to working on an EAD outbreak response, veterinarians may need to complete pre-deployment training, with these requirements varying between states and territories. On occasion there may not be considered a billable activity.

Some governments offer ongoing field-based training and online modules. The state or territory where you are registered may contact you with training opportunities. This can even be during times when there is no active outbreak.

In some states, a pool of casual and contracted vets are provided with ongoing training.

During a response

Some states will only provide training as a deployment activity during an outbreak.

Training and briefings are provided by the Control Centre. This is part of your induction and is a billable activity.

EAD response training may be eligible for Continuing Professional Development points.

Online training

[Enrol in EAD foundation course PDF](#) (Animal Health Australia)

[Online training courses](#) (Animal Health Australia)

If there is an EAD outbreak in your area, your practice may be affected.

This impact will depend on the:

- disease
- control measures employed
- extent of the outbreak.

For highly infectious livestock diseases such as foot-and-mouth disease, movements onto farms in the affected area will be tightly controlled. This includes veterinary visits to farms.

This would lead to reduced work for local practices that service farms. You may be able to offset this impact by contracting services to the response, including through your staff.

The state or territory involved in a response will coordinate contract arrangements.

Will my veterinary staff be engaged in a response?

In an EAD incident, the responding state or territory needs staff who know the area and local industries.

For contracted veterinary practices in the affected area, there may be opportunities for both vets and other staff to be involved. Preference may be given to people in industries adversely affected by the outbreak.

If your staff are directly engaged by the government, they will be paid by the state or territory for the term of their engagement. They will need to negotiate with you about leave from your veterinary practice for that term.

Business owners may charge out veterinary time at well in excess of \$224/hour for services provided within the practice. The contractor hourly rate may be less than you charge out for services at your practice.

A charge out rate includes non-billable time vets spend completing tasks in a day, such as record keeping. The hourly rate paid to contractors in an EAD response is paid for every hour worked. This may be up to 8-10 hours a day at the height of the response.

The hourly rate of contracted veterinarians is set at the productivity rate because as a contracted veterinarian engaged in an emergency animal disease response you are likely to be contracted for a continuous period (weeks or months) to undertake the work required, with an average billable working day of 8-10 hours of professional fees at the height of an EAD response. In general, in veterinary practice it would be unusual for vets to be able to use the charge out rate for all working hours of the day for weeks on end.

Non-veterinary staff may also be able to work on the EAD response. They will be paid the same salary rates as all non-professional, temporary response staff.

The [national guidance document on the engagement of private veterinarians during an EAD response](#) sets out a national approach to:

- how vets can be engaged in a response
- pay and conditions for their employment.

This guidance is agreed by:

- the Animal Health Committee
- Australian Government Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- state and territory governments
- the Australian Veterinary Association (AVA)

Taking part in a response can reinforce your knowledge and experience and can give you the chance to learn new skills.

During a response, you're on the journey with producers and communities on the front line, from disease detection to management and recovery. You can make a significant contribution to positive outcomes for animal health and your community.

If you're a vet, and the government is seeking your help with an outbreak response, please consider getting involved. You may well be one of the heroes guiding a distressed community to a new beginning.

If you're a private vet, sign up now to get involved in a future emergency animal disease response.

Register your interest in your state or territory

We encourage you to share your feedback.

On the engagement process

Provide your feedback to the state or territory government that engaged you.

Do this through the veterinary liaison officer in the response.

Queries on how an EAD response is undertaken

Any EAD response uses the Australasian Inter-service Incident Management System (AIIMS). This system is used by all emergency services to manage natural disaster and other emergencies (such as flood, fire, storms).

AIIMS includes a good induction process and use of Standard Operating Procedures. This helps ensure that all parties understand their obligations.

There may be times when a private vet has concerns with an aspect of the response. It is important that these views are reported and, if necessary, addressed.

You must adhere to the reporting mechanisms in place during a response. This is most likely through your immediate team leader or the veterinary liaison position.

It is not appropriate to voice concerns or adverse opinions publicly. This may lead to a loss of public confidence in the overall response.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/agriculture-land/animal/health/engagement-of-private-veterinarians>